Gp Capt Narayanan had an ineffable enthusiasm for indigenous guided missiles. He was a great admirer of the strong arm approach of the Russian Missile Development Programme. “When it could be done there, why not here, where space research has already prepared the soil for a bonanza of missile technology?” Narayanan used to needle me.

The bitter lessons of the two wars in 1962 and 1965 had left the Indian leadership with little choice in the matter of achieving self-reliance in military hardware and weapon systems. A large number of Surfaceto-Air Missiles (SAMs) were obtained from the USSR to guard strategic locations. Gp Capt Narayanan passionately advocated the development of these missiles in the country.

While working together on RATO motors and on the Missile Panel, Narayanan and I played the roles of student and teacher interchangeably wherever required. He was very eager to learn about rocketry and I was very curious to know about airborne weapon systems. The depth of Narayanan’s conviction and his force of application were inspiring. Right from the day of our pre-dawn visit to the Tilpat Range with Prof. Sarabhai, Narayanan was always